

Scientists Show Baby Mammoth Preserved for 50,000 Years in Siberia

Researchers in Russia's Siberia area are showing the public what they say are the 50,000-year-old remains of a baby mammoth.

Melting permafrost led to the animal's discovery. They are calling it the best-preserved mammoth body ever found.

Named Yana by the scientists, the female mammoth weighs more than 100 kilograms and is 120 centimeters tall.

Scientists believe that Yana was one year old when she died. Her remains are among several mammoth carcasses that have been recovered.

The remains of a 50,000-year-old baby mammoth was uncovered by melting permafrost in Russia's Siberia, Dec. 23, 2024. (Michil Yakovlev, Mammoth Museum at the Russian North-Eastern Federal University telegram channel via AP)

Yana was found among the melting permafrost at Batagaika crater in the far-eastern Russian area of Yakutia. Known as the "gateway to the underworld," scientists have found remains of other ancient animals there, including bison, horses and dogs.

Permafrost is soil that remains frozen for a period of years or more. As the permafrost in Siberia melts, discoveries of prehistoric animals are becoming more common.

Scientists at Russia's North-Eastern Federal University will study Yana's remains. The university has a research center and museum specifically for mammoths.

Scientists at the university described the find as "exceptional." They said Yana would give researchers additional information about how mammoths lived and how they changed to survive in their surroundings.

I'm Anna Matteo.

The Associated Press reported this story. Anna Matteo adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

permafrost - n. ดินที่ยังคงเป็นน้ำแข็งเป็นระยะเวลาหลายปีหรือนานกว่านั้นโดยไม่ละลาย

preserved - adj. ซึ่งได้รับการเก็บรักษาไว้ในสภาพดี; ไม่เปลี่ยนแปลงมากนักจากสภาพต่างๆ เช่น อายุ การสึกหรอ หรือสภาพอากาศ

carcass - n. ซากสัตว์ที่ตายแล้ว

crater - n. หลุมกลมบนพื้นโลกที่มีขอบชันและก้นโค้ง ซึ่งมักเกิดจากการชนของอุกกาบาตหรือกิจกรรมของภูเขาไฟ

exceptional - adj. ที่ไม่เหมือนใคร; น่าทึ่งหรือน่าประหลาดใจ

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What ancient remains are researchers in Russia's Siberia area showing to the public?

- A) A 50,000-year-old baby mammoth's remains.
- B) An ancient bison from Yakutia.
- C) A newly discovered crater.
- D) Evidence of volcanic activity.

2. What natural phenomenon is credited with the discovery of the baby mammoth?

- A) A sudden earthquake.
- B) Volcanic eruption.
- C) Melting permafrost.
- D) A severe snowstorm.

3. How do scientists describe the condition of the discovered mammoth body?

- A) Partially decomposed.
- B) The best-preserved ever found.
- C) Recently unearthed but damaged.
- D) Skeletal remains only.

4. What name did scientists give to the female mammoth?

- A) Siberia.
- B) Yakutia.
- C) Yana.
- D) Matteo.

5. According to the article, what is Yana's approximate weight?

- A) Exactly 100 kilograms.
- B) Less than 100 kilograms.
- C) More than 100 kilograms.

D) Around 120 kilograms.

6. How old do scientists estimate Yana was at the time of her death?

- A) Less than a year old.
- B) Exactly one year old.
- C) Approximately two years old.
- D) Several years old.

7. What does the article state about Yana's remains in relation to other mammoth discoveries?

- A) They are the only mammoth remains ever found.
- B) They are the first mammoth remains to be recovered.
- C) They are among several mammoth carcasses that have been recovered.
- D) They are the largest mammoth remains ever recovered.

8. According to the specific information provided in Paragraph 6, when was the baby mammoth uncovered?

- A) 50,000 years ago.
- B) December 23, 2024.
- C) In the distant past.
- D) The article does not specify a date of uncovering.

9. In which specific location was Yana discovered?

- A) The Mammoth Museum.
- B) Russia's Siberia area.
- C) Batagaika crater in Yakutia.
- D) A research center at the university.

10. What nickname is given to the Batagaika crater?

- A) The 'frozen wasteland.'
- B) The 'gateway to the underworld.'
- C) The 'mammoth burial ground.'
- D) The 'ancient animal preserve.'

11. Besides mammoths, what other types of ancient animal remains have been found at Batagaika crater?

- A) Only insects and plants.
- B) Only birds and fish.

- C) Bison, horses, and dogs.
- D) Dinosaurs and reptiles.

12. How is 'permafrost' defined in the article?

- A) Soil that quickly thaws and refreezes.
- B) Soil that is permanently wet.
- C) Soil that remains frozen for a period of years or more.
- D) Soil rich in prehistoric plant life.

13. What trend is observed regarding discoveries of prehistoric animals as permafrost melts in Siberia?

- A) They are becoming less common.
- B) They are becoming more common.
- C) They are remaining stable in number.
- D) They are exclusively found in museums.

14. Which institution is mentioned as responsible for studying Yana's remains?

- A) The Associated Press.
- B) VOA Learning English.
- C) Russia's North-Eastern Federal University.
- D) The Batagaika Crater Institute.

15. How did scientists at the university characterize the discovery of Yana?

- A) As a routine finding.
- B) As an unfortunate accident.
- C) As 'exceptional.'
- D) As a minor scientific interest.